

A student hostel named after the RSS's third Sarsanghchalak Balasaheb Deoras. Source: Photos by Rajiv Pundir and Nalin Mehta, 26 July 2020.

ABVKA's Academic Focus: Higher Pass Percentages, Cultural Layering and Competitive Exams

The ABVKA is organically linked to the Sangh scholastic network. It runs two types of schools: formal institutions and informal ones called Ekal Vidyalayas, which consist of a single mobile teacher holding open classes in remote and tribal villages without formal schools. It was managing 4,190 schools in India's tribal areas by 2019 (see Table 14.1). When I asked ABVKA's Atul Jog about the primary difference between schools run by his organisation and those run by the government or other private entities, he explained that the 'academic curriculum is the same' in ABVKA schools. So, they follow curricula set by central education boards like CBSE or the state education boards. But the schools add two additional layers of cultural education. 'We always ensure that tribal community's custom is celebrated and we celebrate its festivals,' he said. Along with this, the schools focus on teaching students the stories of 'mahapurush [great men] who have done something for society, so that a feeling of deshbhakti [patriotism] grows in them'. In the border areas of Assam and Nagaland, for example, he said that ABVKA schools organise trips to the army's border outposts on the festival of Rakhi. Students ritualistically tie rakhis (symbolising sibling-bonding)